INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

a mediastudies.press
open reader

Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

Edited by David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

© 2026 David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

Works not in the public domain are licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial 4.0 International *(CC BY-NC 4.0)*. This license allows you to share, copy, distribute and transmit the text; to adapt the text for non-commercial purposes of the text providing attribution is made to the authors *(but not in any way that suggests that they endorse you or your use of the work)*.



Published by:
mediastudies.press
414 W. Broad St.
Bethlehem, PA 18018, USA

Copy-editing: Emily Alexander

Cover design: Natascha Chtena

Landing page: mediastudies.press/iacmedia

Open Reader series - issn *(online)* 2770-940X | issn *(print)* 3143-4509

isbn 978-1-951399-33-7 *(print)* | isbn 978-1-951399-30-6 *(pdf)*

isbn 978-1-951399-32-0 *(epub)* | isbn 978-1-951399-31-3 *(html)*

doi 10.64629/3f8575cb.638fbdwo | lccn 2025938544

Edition 1 published in August 2026

Contents

Introduction: The Promise and Vulnerability of Independent, Alternative, and Community Media
David W. Park and Meghan Grosse xvii

PART 1: CONCEPTUALIZING INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA

There is No Alternative: The Critical Potential of Alternative Media in the Face of Neoliberalism
Linus Andersson 1

Uncommunicative Partners: Social Movement Media Analysis and Radcial Educators
John D. H. Downing 20

Communication and Struggles for Alternatives
Christian Fuchs 29

What We Talk About When We Talk About "Media Independence"
Karl Karpinnen and Hallvard Moe 43

The Unbearable Lightness of Being Alternative: Idealism-Realism and Purism-Pragmatism in Greek Alternative Media
Dimitra L. Milioni and Pantelis Vatikiotis. 59

PART 2: HISTORY, MEMORY, AND ARCHIVES

Hand-Made Memories: Remediating Cultural Memory in DIY Feminist Networks
Red Chidgey 83

Being a Child of the Mines: Youth Magazines and Comics in the Copperbelt
Enid Guene 93

Social Participation in Indonesian Media and Art: Echoes from the Past, Visions for the Future
Edwin Jurriëns 112

Learning from the History of Alternative Communciation Networks
Félix Tréguer, Dominique Trudel, and Mélanie Dulong de Rosnay 134

A Brief History of CCLM/CLMP
Pauline Uchmanowicz 152

Promising Prospects, and the Hurdles Along the Way: Sharing and Archiving Community Media Content Online
Joost van Beek 163

PART 3: POLICY, REGULATIONS, AND GOVERNMENT INTERVENTION

Media at the Margins: Policy and Practice in American, Canadian, and British Community Television
Christopher Ali 173

News by Any Other Name: Community Radio Journalism in India
Bridget Backhaus 192

'In the Waiting Room': Digitsation and Post-Neoliberalism in Buenos Aires
Geoff Baker 208

From Revolution to Reform: Recommendations for Spectrum Policy in Transitional Tunisia
Moez Chakchouk, Danielle Kehl, Jochai Ben-Avie, and Kate Coyer 244

From Media Niche to Policy Spotlight: Mapping Community-Media Policy Change in Latin America
Arne Hintz 269

Community Radio Contradictions in Canada: Learning from Volunteers Impacted by Commercialising Policies and Practices
Gretchen King and Omme-Salma Rahemtullah 282

PART 4: PRODUCTION AND DISTRIBUTION

Podcasting About Yourself and Challenging Norms: An Investigation of Independent Women Podcasters in Denmark
Freja Sørine Adler Berg 305

The Business of DIY: Characteristics, Motives and Ideologies of Microindependent Record Labels
Robin den Drijver and Erik Hitters 323

Intervention for Inclusivity: Gender Politics and Indie Game Development
Stephanie Fisher and Alison Harvey 342

From Art House to Your House: The Distribution of Quality Cinema on Home Video
Daniel Herbert 358

SoundCloud and Bandcamp as Alternative Music Platforms
David Hesmondhalgh, Ellis Jones, and Andreas Rauh 373

Indie or Mainstream? Tensions and Nuances between the Alternative and the Mainstrean in Indie Games
Ólivier Pérez-Latorre 393

Making Media Together: Experiences of Aboriginal Participation within Co-Creative Remote Media Production Teams
Laura McDowell. 408

Participatory Film Production as Media Practice
Antoni Roig Telo 427

PART 5: LABOR, FUNDING, AND PROMOTION

Indie Cinema and Short Film Assemblage
Thomas Barker 449

Independent Canadian Music in the Streaming Age
Andrew deWaard, Brian Fauteux, and Brianne Selman 459

Crowdfunding for Independent Print Media: E-Commerce, Marketing, and Business Development
Peter Konhäusner, Marius Thielmann, Veronica Thielmann, Veronica Câmpian, and Dan-Cristian Dabija 489

'Let's Keep Music Special. F—Spotify': On-Demand Streaming and the Controversy over Artist Royalties
Lee Marshall 513

DIY or Die? A Typology of DIY Careers in the Portuguese Independent Music Scenes
Ana Oliveira 528

The Political Economy of Financially Successful Independent Hip-Hop Artists
Geoff Ostrove. 544

Autonomy, Integration, and the Work of Cultural Intermediation in Indie Games
Matthew E. Perks, Felan Parker, Jennifer R. Whitson, Gabrielle Lavenir, Ceyda Yolgörmez, Pierson Browne, and Brian Schram 564

Seeking Deep Relations in a Precarious Industry: Addressing Mental Health through Independent Videogame Development
Paulo Ruffino 584

PART 6: MESSAGES, NARRATIVES, AND REPRESENTATIONS

What I Know Now: Radio as a Means of Empowerment for Women of Lived Prison Experience
Heather Anderson and Charlotte Bedford. 603

Are You Okay? Mental Health Narratives in Art Zines from the Zineopolis Collection
Jackie Batey 619

"I Want to Tell You about My Life Now": The Voice of Palestinian Refugees in Frontiers of Dreams and Fears
Catherine Burwell 633

American Realities on Public Television: Analysis of the Independent Television Service's Documentaries, 2007-2016
Caty Borum Chattoo, Patricia Aufderheide, Michele Alexander, and Chandler Green 647

Against Hollywood: American Independent Film as a Critical Cultural Movement
Sherry B. Ortner. 670

Alternative Media, Self-Representation and Arab-American Women
Kenza Oumlil 689

PART 7: AUDIENCES: PARTICIPATION, ENGAGEMENT, AND ACCESS

Conventions, Computers, and Collective Action (1991-2007)
Francesca Coppa 709

Coming Out as Popular Media Practice: The Politics of Queer Youth Coming Out on YouTube
Sander De Ridder and Frederik Dhaenens 743

Public Value and Participation of Civil Society—A Case for Public Service or Community Media?
Manuela Grünangerl, Josef Trappel, and Corinna Wenzel. 759

Moments of Danger: The Struggle for Community-based Public Radio in Baltimore
Jason Loviglio. 784

Making Media Public: On Revolutionary Street Screenings in Egypt
Nina Grønlykke Mollerup and Sherief Gaber 800

The Death of Indie Hip-Hop?:The Blurry Lines Between the Majors and Independent Hip-Hop
Christopher Vito 815

PART 8: JOURNALISM AND THE PUBLIC

Podcasting as Public Media: The Future of U.S. News, Public Affairs, and Educational Podcasts
Patricia Aufderheide, David Lieberman, Atika Alkhallouf, and Jiji Majiri Ugboma 841

The Future of Public Service Media and the Internet
Alessandra D'Arma, Christian Fuchs, Minna Horowitz, and Klaus Unterberger 861

Community Radio and Peace-building in Kenya
Jessica Gustafsson 871

Intersectionality in Autonomous Journalism Practices
Sandra Jeppesen and Media Action Research Group 887

Amplifying Counter-Public Spheres on Social Media: News Sharing of Alternative Versus Traditional Media After the 2019 Chilean Uprising
Juan Pablo Luna, Sergio Toro, and Sebastián Valenzuelap 906

Iranian Internet Cinema, a Cinema of Embodied Protest: Imperfect, Amateur, Small, Unauthorized, Global
Hamid Naficy 926

Media Representations of Burundi's 2020 Elections in Belgium and Burundi
Caroline Williamson Sinalo 941

Digital Amplification of Fringe Voices: Alternative Media and Street Politics in Hong Kong
Yidong Wang 959

PART 9: COMMUNITY AND LOCALISM

Not Just Surviving but Thriving: Practices That Sustain a New Generation of Latin American Community Media Makers
Diana Coryat 983

Community Media Makers and the Mediation of Difference: Claiming Citizenship and Belongingness
Lola de Koning, Elaine Nolten, and Koen Leurs 999

Failties at the Borders: Stalled Activist Media Projects in East Africa
Christina Dunbar-Hester 1015

Wireless Mesh Networks as Community Hubs: Analysis of Small-Scale Wireless Mesh Networks and Community-Centered Technology Training
Jamie Alexander Greig 1035

'Neither Silent Nor Invisible': Anti-poverty Communication in the San Francisco Bay Area
Dorothy Kidd and Bernadette Barker-Plummer 1063

Core Dimensions of Community Radio in Action: The Case of Ghana
Lawrence Naaikuur and Africanus L. Diedong 1077

Communicative Sovereignty in Latin America: The Case of Radio Mundo Real
Katherine Reilly 1096

Combatting Cultural 'Nerve Gas': Maintaining Traditional Media and Culture through Local Media Production in Australia, Canada and Mexico
Ian Watson 1115

PART 10: NETWORKS AND SOCIAL MEDIA

Activist Networks
Joshua D. Atkinson. 1133

Why Diverse Zines Matter: A Case Study of the People of Color Zines Project
Melanie Ramdarshan Bold 1157

FCJ-193 Harbouring Dissent: Greek Independent and Social Media and the Antifascist Movement
Sky Croeser and Tim Highfield 1172

The Case for Alternative Social Media
Robert W. Gehl 1189

The Opium of the Paquete: State Censorship, Private Self-Censorship, and the Content-Distribution Strategies of Cuba's Emergent, Independent Digital-Media Start-Ups
Ted A. Henken. 1209

Bridging the Open Web and APIs: Alternative Social Media Alongside the Corporate Web
Jack Jamieson, Naomi Yamashita, and Rhonda McEwen 1233

Building Wi-Fi Networks for Communities: Three Canadian Cases
Catherine Middleton and Barbara Crow 1254

PART 11: ACTIVISM AND RESISTANCE

Punks' Jungle: São Paulo
Rodrigo Lopes de Barros 1281

The Lumad Struggle for Social and Environmental Justice: Alternative Media in a Socio-Environmental Movement in the Philippines
Belinda F. Espiritu 1315

Indymedia and the Long Story of Rebellion Against Neoliberal Capitalsim
Natalie Fenton 1332

Bearing Witness to Authoritarianism and Commoning through Video Activism and Political Film-Making after the Gezi Protests
Özge Özdüzen 1339

Alternative Media in Latin American Grassroots Integration: Building Networks and New Agendas
Daniela Parra 1355

Feminist Media as Alternative Media? Theorising Feminist Media from the Perspective of Alternative Media Studies
Jenny Gunnarsson Payne 1374

Media Activism from Above and Below: Lessons From the 1940s American Reform Movement
Victor Pickard. 1390

Queer Blogs and Digital Archives: A Tactical Shift Towards Queer Utopia in Bangladesh
Mohammed Mizanur Rashid 1405

CHAPTER 76

Queer Blogs and Digital Archives: A Tactical Shift Towards Queer Utopia in Bangladesh

Mohammed Mizanur Rashid

Media Fields Journal, no. 17 (2022).

In the Summer of 2019, a particular name was making its rounds in the LGBTQIA+ community of Bangladesh. The name was of a newly formed archival website, *Mondro*, created primarily as a queer literary digital archive and blogging platform for LGBTQIA+ subjects in a country that criminalizes people with non-normative sexual orientations and transgender identities through social stigmatization and constitutional law.[1] The hateful rendering of LGBTQIA+ subjects in the nation-state's legislation, law enforcement, religious ideologies, popular media and culture, public spheres, and society meant that such an archive needed to function by remaining hidden from the government and the public. Functioning as a not-for-profit, volunteer-run cultural organization, *Mondro* started as a blog-posting website with only three contributors. Within two and half years the site has grown into the country's largest queer literary archive and publishing platform, with forty- five volunteers currently working in the areas of publication, research, cultural text and performance archival, and social media outreach. In addition to functioning as an archival and blogging website, *Mondro* also supports LGBTQIA+ poets, performers, writers, and thinkers from all over Bangladesh, by arranging mentorship workshops that range from topics on mental health, gender and sexuality-based violence and trauma, and suicide prevention. In this essay, however, my

[1] MONDRO, https://mondro.org (accessed February 3, 2022).

BY-NC

objective is not only to describe *Mondro*'s vital role in community organizing and queer curation in Bangladesh, but also to analyze how the queer blogging and archival website challenges traditional blogging platforms in the country through counterpublic formation.[2] I argue that by functioning as a digital counter-space that promotes solidarity and affective communication between queer publics and their allies, *Mondro* continues to operate as both reminder of and resistance to the dominant cissexism and heteronormative ideology rampant in traditional blogging communities and the Bangladeshi digital platforms writ large. As queer subjects begin to adapt to oppressive digital networks and platforms, queer blogs such as *Mondro* continue to provide an avenue to tactically challenge established community blogs by uncovering their oppressive logics.

Blogging emerged as a form of digital media in Bangladesh in 2005 with the inception of *Somewhere in... blog*, the first Bangladeshi blogging platform. Since then, blog communication has established itself as one of the most significant alternative media forms in Bangladesh, challenging mainstream and popular media production and raising questions around hegemonic discourses upheld by the political and religious institutions of power.[3] Community blogging functions as one of Bangladesh's primary platforms for digital resistance and community organizing against social inequalities and oppressive government policies, as seen many times over the years during local and national uprisings such as the BDR Mutiny in 2009, the Shahbagh Mass Protests in 2013, and the Student protests against Tax on Education in 2015. In these sociopolitical movements, community blogging has played crucial roles for activism as bloggers functioned as citizen journalists and active protesters both online and offline. Through such blogger engagements and activism, the Bangladeshi blogosphere gained a reputation for being liberal, unbiased, pro-nationalist, and most importantly, progressive. Let us take the role bloggers have played during the BDR Mutiny as an example. In late February 2009, the blogging community made the first report of the BDR Mutiny, when a section of the paramilitary force for the nation's border protection rebelled and assumed control over their headquarters in Pilkhana, Dhaka, killing fifty-six other army officers and holding their families hostage in the process. Fahmidul Haq, in his chapter on citizen journalists and the Bangla blog community in *Bangladesh's Changing Mediascape*, outlines how a blogger named Onrino from the *Somewhere in... blog* community reported on the BDR tragedy almost instantaneously.[4] Onrino's one-sentence blog post read, "Since the morning exchange of fires is heard inside BDR," and this created a web of communications both inside and outside the blogging community ensuring public engagement against the mutiny. While law enforcement agencies worked hard to bring the situation under control, the public's demands and protests led to the eventual surrender of the mutineers on the fourth day.

The Bangladeshi blogging community and blog practices, in comparison to traditional forms of mass-media, were increasingly seen as progressive, liberal, and the nation's primary platform for digital resistance against social, cultural, and political oppression. Another ex-

---

[2] Gayatri Gopinath, *Unruly Visions* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2018).

[3] Michel Foucault, *The Archeology of Knowledge* (London: Routledge, 2002); *Antonio Gramsci, A Gramsci Reader: Selected Writings 1916–1935*, ed. David Forgacs (New York: New York University Press, 2000).

[4] Fahmidul Haque, "The Profile and Activity of Citizen Journalists: A Study on Bangla Blog Community," in *Bangladesh's Changing Mediascape*, ed. Brian Shoesmith and Jude William Genilo (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2013), 269.

ample of such resistance was the blogging community's contribution during the Shahbagh Mass Protests in 2013. The Shahbagh Protests, named after the neighborhood of Shahbagh within the city of Dhaka, were mass public demonstrations carried out to force the government to bring the war criminals from Bangladesh's 1971 Independence War to justice. The pro-nationalist public demonstrations demanded the trials of a handful of powerful political leaders who had climbed into positions of political power after the independence of Bangladesh. These political leaders had originally worked against the nation's independence due to their allegiance to former West Pakistan, commanding anti-independence groups during the 1971 war for Bangladesh's freedom and were responsible for the deaths of numerous Bengali freedom fighters and pro-liberation nationalists and intellectuals during the time. These leaders belonged to a political party called the Jamaat-e-Islami Bangladesh which is fundamentally the post-independence name of Jamaat-e-Islami Pakistan, a political party that was responsible for war atrocities during 1971. Interestingly, the political ideology of the Jamaat-e- Islami Bangladesh depends on Islamist Sharia'a law and the ultimate creation of a Bangladeshi Islamic State. The opposition against such a political party began to grow as the progressive and secular publics of the country started to engage in producing pro-nationalist and secular narratives primarily through blogging websites. These events are aptly recorded in Fahmidul Huq's study on Bangladeshi blogs, in which he analyzes the importance of bloggers in the movement towards bringing war criminals to justice during the Shahbag Protests of 2013. Focusing on how blog writers participate and contribute to the politics of nation-building, Huq writes in his essay:

> In contemporary Bangladesh bringing war criminals to trial is a big political issue and bloggers have joined the row. They have created a mass campaign of protests against the alleged war criminals, collecting hundreds of thousands of signatures to pressurize the government into bringing the war criminals to trial. Bloggers worked for this in the real world and through their blogs. Two blog community authorities actively supported this program by opening a corner in the front page of the blog devoted to bringing the alleged criminals to justice.[5]

These two examples suggest that the Bangladeshi blogging community in general has consistently been progressive and reactionary in the face of social and political oppressions and injustices. Much of these protests and activism can be better understood by how the blogging community engages in community blogging rather than in isolation. In other words, while the medium of the blog is mostly associated with individual people in the contemporary digital mediascape—where each digital blogspace works as a personal scope for mediated expression—in the context of Bangladesh, blogging always eventuated in the form of a community.[6] Any Bangladeshi blogger who wishes to partake in blogging is first required to be a member of a blogging community like *Somewhere in... blog*, *Sachalayatan*, or *Amarblog*. This process does not mean that blogging websites based on individual people cannot exist in Bangladesh, but it simply suggests that most bloggers have a membership in at least one of the aforementioned digital blogging websites as their primary engagement in blogging. Additionally, already being a part of a blogging community opens up the possibilities of certain

[5] Haque, "The Profile and Activity of Citizen Journalists," 271.

[6] Arjun Appadurai, "Disjuncture and Difference in the Global Cultural Economy," in *Media and Cultural Studies Keyworks*, ed. Meenakshi Gigi Durham and Douglas M. Kellner (Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishing, 2001), 584–603.

kinds of publicness based on blog discourse and affect, and in times of community organizing and protests, such familiarities between community members definitely help. However, despite being equipped with key foundations of digital resistance and community activism, and historically functioning as a medium of confrontation with oppressive political establishments and religious ideologies, the Bangladeshi blog-publics remain selectively unconcerned at the vitriolic representation and brutal treatment of queer subjects all over the nation-state. Such was the case when, in 2014, the LGBTQIA+ community officially came out in public. Additionally, queer people were made subject to online hate speech and constant abuse, even within the blogging community. It became increasingly obvious that the progressive and secular blog-publics of the Bangladeshi blogging community held specific reservations about which oppressions they would protest, and which ones they would allow to continue.

The LGBTQIA+ movement in Bangladesh was first visible in 2014 when Bangladeshi LGBTQIA+ rights activists Xulhaz Mannan, Mahbub Rabbi, and Ali Asgar organized the country's first Pride Rally on 14 April 2014, the first day of the Bengali New Year, 1421.[7] Queer activism may not have begun with this movement, but it demanded visibility and acknowledgement from the government and the general people, for the first time in the nation's history. Almost a hundred LGBTQIA+ people and allies took part in a rainbow-themed procession on the morning of 14 April as the assembly walked from the Fine Arts Building in Dhaka University to the Intercontinental Hotel on Minto Road. The objective was clear: abolish Section 377 of the Bangladesh Penal Code—the legislation that deems diverse sexual orientations and acts as illegal and punishable by a life sentence or even death—and establish the basic human right to love. The first wave of LGBTQIA+ rights activism, as I will henceforth address this, continued through 2015 with the organization of the second Pride Rally despite violent reactions from both the nationalist ruling party and the country's homophobic and transphobic religious institutions. Nevertheless, severe backlash and life-threatening circumstances created by religious extremist groups like Ansarulla Bangla Team (ABT), an Islamic extremist organization responsible for the death of many secular Bangladeshi blog writers, and the antipathy of government and law enforcement agencies resulted in the cancellation of the third Pride Rally in 2016. The organizers and anyone related to the Pride Rallies received death threats and feared for their lives. Amidst the fear, Xulhaz Mannan and the other founders of the LGBTQIA+ organization *Roopban* stopped organizing physically and moved online. The *Roopban* magazine that complemented the formation of the organization also ceased print.[8] On 25 April 2016, key Bangladeshi LGBTQIA+ movement founders Xulhaz Mannan and Mahbub Rabbi were murdered in their own apartments in Dhaka by armed assailants who later identified themselves as members of an Islamic extremist group called Ansar-al Islam.[9] With the death of prominent LGBTQIA+ rights leaders, the *Roopban* human rights organization ceased to operate in Bangladesh, and its organizational members either went into hiding or left the country entirely under conditions of fatal danger.[10]

[7] Inge Amundsen, "The Ruins of Bangladesh's LGBT Community," *East Asia Forum*, 23 March 2018.

[8] "Publications," Roopbaan, accessed 26 August 2021, roopbaan.org/publications/

[9] Faisal Mahmud, "Six sentenced to death in Bangladesh for killing LGBTQ activists," *Aljazeera*, 31 August 2021, www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/8/31/six-death-penalty-bangladesh-lgbtq-gay-rights-activists-murder.

[10] Saad Hammadi and Aisha Gani, "Founder of Bangladesh's first and only LGBT magazine killed," *The Guardian*, 25 April 2016.



Figure 1. Pride Rally, 2014

Interestingly, the continuous assault on and oppression of queer subjects after 2014, including the deaths of Xulhaz Mannan and Mahabub Rabbi, and the forced migration of many LGBTQIA+ people and allies like Ali Asgar— who was forced to leave Bangladesh for the United States for fear of being killed—was never protested in the traditional Bangladeshi blogosphere. Extreme circumstances such as public shaming, social isolation, death threats, and even lynching led the queer population to become anonymous in the virtual worlds of social media, blogs, and digital archives. However, their efforts to protest through anonymous blog writing also proved futile as their posts were bombarded with hateful comments and later deleted by the blog administrators. The first wave of the LGBTQIA+ movement in Bangladesh would therefore face a grim setback. As one queer activist (whom I will call Robin), explains in an interview with me, this setback was also due to the rising number of homophobic and transphobic publics in the Bangladeshi networked media.[11] Robin suggests that 2014—which for the LBGTQIA+ community was when anti-queer violence began to reach its peak in Bangladesh—was also when the ruling political party Bangladesh Awami League got reelected to power based partly on the promises made during its previous term (2008–2014) around a digital revolution that assured high- speed networked communication services for all.[12] Networked and digital media infrastructures saw a rapid growth in the years leading up to 2014, and more people than ever had access to the Internet and associated networked media services. This growth had profound implications on public communication, information dissemination, and more specifically, exacerbated institutional and ideological

[11] Robin, interview with the author, Dhaka, Bangladesh, 31 January 2022.

[12] "Bangladesh Awami League announced its Election Manifesto, 2014," *ALBD*, 28 December 2013, www.albd.org/articles/news/27097/Bangladesh-Awami-League-announced-it's-Election-Manifesto, 2014.

control over permissible sexual identities and practices. The networked mediascape of Bangladesh, including micro-blogging and social media sites such as Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube, was frequented by the general homophobic and transphobic publics, who, primarily indoctrinated in religious (in most cases Islamist) beliefs, see non-normative sexual identities and practices as prohibited not only by religion, but also the country's legislation. These publics particularly affected the blogging communities, and as more people joined every day, Bangladeshi blogs started losing their initial identity as platforms that fought for justice and equity, and simply became another space for digital communication.[13] This process became increasingly evident when queer people in these networked spaces were the subjects of extreme hate, repulsive language, and murder threats. Community blogs that once functioned as domains of sociocultural movements against systems of social oppression now either turned against queer subjects or remained silent in response to their everyday oppression. Such online hate and aggression is further legitimized by the state, who participates in systemic and structural violence against LGBTQIA+ individuals by not recognizing their socio- cultural existence or constitutional rights.[14] It became increasingly clear to the queer population of the country that the publics of the blogosphere made a clear distinction between the rights of queer and non-queer subjects. Bloggers whose strong efforts have led to popular and political uprisings such as the Shahbagh Mass Protests in 2013, have seemingly forgotten how to raise their voices against queer oppression. Additionally, certain blog chapters that focus on the oppression and struggles of women in Bangladesh remarkably kept quiet on the issue of queer rights. Scholars have mentioned that specific digital spaces may work as safe options for feminists and their allies to raise and discuss social problems and solutions.[15] While there are several women's rights organizations in Bangladesh—from the women's wings of political parties to non-government organizations (NGOs) such as Naripokkho, Steps Towards Development, Adhunika, and Ain o Salish Kendro (ASK) that are active in online networks—it is interesting to note how none of these progressive organizations advocate for queer rights in Bangladesh, despite resisting Islamic fundamentalist movements.[16] Clearly, there is a lack of what Audre Lorde calls "systems of shared support" as the most vocal feminist groups in Bangladesh continue to downplay the importance of intersectionality when it comes to the dehumanization of marginal LGBTQIA+ communities.[17]

Queer subjects in Bangladesh quickly realized the importance of a digital counter-space that anti-queer networked publics in general would not frequent. The digital queer counterspace *Mondro* emerged out of the need to provide digital safe spaces for queer subjects

[13] Fahmidul Haque, "The Profile and Activity of Citizen Journalists: A Study on Bangla Blog Community," in *Bangladesh's Changing Mediascape*, ed. Brian Shoesmith and Jude William Genilo (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2013), 259–276.

[14] Nur E Makbul and Md. Ashraful Goni, "Bangladesh's Invisible Cyberqueers: Self-Image, Identity Management, and Erotic Expressions on Grindr," in *LGBTQ Digital Cultures: A Global Perspectiv*e, ed. Paromita Pain (New York, NY: Routledge, 2022), 210–223.

[15] Rosemary Clark-Parsons, "Building a Digital Girl Army: The Cultivation of Feminist Spaces Online," *New Media and Society* 20, no.6 (2018), 2125– 2144; Joy Jenkins and J. David Wolfgang. "A Space for Women: Online Commenting Forums as Indicators of Civility and Feminist Community- Building," in *Mediating Misogyny: Technology, Gender, and Harassment*, ed. J. R. Vickery and T. Everbach (Basington, England: Palgrave Macmillan, 2018), 247–268.

[16] Firdaus Azim, "Feminist Struggles in Bangladesh," *Feminist Review* 80, no.1 (2005), 194–197.

[17] Azim, "Feminist Struggles in Bangladesh," 194–197.

and allies to communicate, and to ensure the preservation of the knowledges, experiences, and creative expressions of the Bangladeshi queer community. This shift in modality from public digital platforms such as community blogs to more secluded forms of online counter-spaces that deliberately remain hidden is crucial in reorienting the project of queer utopia in Bangladesh towards a more sustainable future. In a nation-state where the dominant public ideology results in violence towards queer subjects, it is important to keep employing tactics that reconsider publicness until conditions are more suitable for queer subjects.[18] Alternate blogging and archival websites not only facilitate a digital space for queer counter-publics to engage in critical and creative expressions, but they do so without having to experience the fear of being seen. *Mondro* again provides a great example. Each of its writers and contributors write under pseudonyms such as "living large in little boxes" or "joker of Hamelin" (translated from Bangla *Hameliner Hashiwala*). Blog writing under such anonymity allows for the safety of these queer subjects, which the nation-state has failed to provide. Additionally, working under the conditions of anonymity allows for the Bangladeshi queer community to function as what Catherine Squires calls "enclave publics," a strategic mobilizing of counter-publics that are more concealed and do not typically engage with the dominant publics in any manner, for their larger goal is to ensure the safety of their public sphere *t*hat is often under intense aggression and oppression from other dominant groups.[19] *Mondro*, a Bengali word that roughly translates to a "deep calling or a sound from within that is difficult to hear from the outside," functions specifically as a platform for Bengali queer enclave publics, hidden from the homophobic and transphobic dominant publics in Bangladesh with no intentions to become publicly available or visible in the near future. Additionally, over the last couple of years, *Mondro* published several works of literature in print. These include the inaugural non-fiction collection on LGBTQIA+ issues in Bangladesh titled *Thahor*, a collection of LGBTQIA+ short stories *Shomaroor*, and an anthology of indigenous LGBTQIA+ literature in Bangladesh titled *Ludong*. These are only made available to the LGBTQIA+ community and allies. It is also important to focus on how *Mondro* identifies itself and evaluates its mission to truly understand its queer world-making project in Bangladesh. On the site, *Mondro* identifies its community as the queer people in Bangladesh whose "existence is denied, voices are silenced, and our organizers are murdered."[20] It states its mission is "to uplift queer voices and promote histories of gender and sexual diversity in Bangladesh in order to sensitize contemporary society." It is crucial to note that the focus on the histories of queerness in Bangladesh is a significant turn towards celebrating practices and identities of gender and sexually diverse subjects within Bangladesh that seeks to reclaim queerness not as something that has been imported from the West, but that has always already been a significant practice within the Bengali sociocultural fabric that expands beyond the South Asian subcontinent. In this sense, *Mondro* reconceptualizes queerness within a far-reaching framework of multiple yet connected historical references and cultural interpretations that may open up new ways of understanding sociocultural, political, and religious narratives and discourses originating from the region. *Mondro*'s use of culturally appropriate imagery and designs that uphold

[18] Michel de Certeau, *The Practice of Everyday Life* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2011).

[19] Catherine Squires, "Rethinking the Black Public Sphere: An Alternative Vocabulary for Multiple Public Spheres," *Communication Theory* 12, no.4 (2002), 446–468.

[20] "What does the name Mondro mean?," *Mondro*, accessed 2 September 2021, mondro.org/about-mondro/.

various aesthetics of Bengali culture and history can also be interpreted as a deliberate move towards constructing publics through design processes. [21]

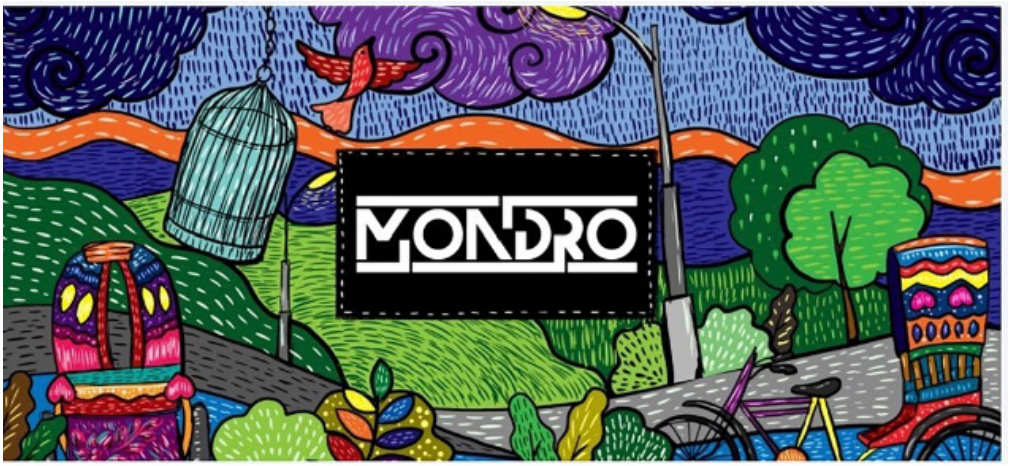


Figure 2. *Mondro*'s use of Cultural Imagery

The emergence of queer blogging communities such as *Mondro* not only demarcates a tactical shift from traditional blogging communities that are now oppressive towards queer subjects in Bangladesh, but it also clearly points to the beginning of a second wave of queer activism in Bangladesh and lays the foundations for a possible queer utopia when certain conditions are achieved. With political and religious ideologies extremely adversative towards queer rights, identities, and existences in the real world, digital communities like *Mondro* provide ways to continue the conversations through creative expression, affective intimacies, queer archiving, and curation in the present, and conditioning and constructing publics for the future. [22] However, it is important to realize that queerness in the context of Bangladesh and Bengali culture is an extremely complex concern. At the least, networked queer activism, to achieve the conditions of queer utopia in Bangladesh, as discussed in this essay, requires an awareness of the dangers of immediately attempting radical shifts and policy alterations in this part of the world. At the same time, activists need to remain hopeful and suggestive of tactical practices that would help set long-term egalitarian conditions and equitable futures.

Author Information

Mohammed Mizanur Rashid (he/they) is Doctoral Candidate in Arts, Technology, and Emerging Communication at The University of Texas at Dallas. Their dissertation Mediated Sexualities explores decolonial approaches to counter-public formation and queer resistance in Bangladeshi digital media. They presented their research on Bangladeshi queer activism at SCMS, WSCA, HASTAC, and Queer Asia.

[21] Carl DiSalvo, "Design and the Construction of Publics," *Design Issues* 25, no.1 (2009), 48–63.

[22] Shaka McGlotten, *Virtual Intimacies: Media, Affect, and Queer Sociality* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2013).

Independent, alternative, and community media occupy an important place in media studies and in the broader cultural imaginary, where they often represent hopes for a better media environment, one less fully controlled by powerful entities and more open to democratic intervention. *Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader* compiles a carefully curated set of 76 open access entries reflecting inclusive and global perspectives in the study of this important domain.

Editors David W. Park and Meghan Grosse divide this substantial work into eleven thematic sections, ranging from production to audiences, activism to policy, labor to localism, and more. As an open educational resource, *Independent, Alternative, and Community Media* is a vast landscape from which instructors and students can find material to fit almost any course that considers the rangy and complex world of independent, alternative, and community media.

DAVID W. PARK is the James D. Vail III Professor of Communication at Lake Forest College. In his scholarship focuses on the history of media studies, applications of social theory to the media, and independent, alternative, and community media. He is a co-director of mediastudies.press and a co-editor of *History of Media Studies*.

MEGHAN GROSSE is an Associate Professor and Chair of Communication and Media Studies at Washington College. Her scholarship explores internet governance policies, independent media, and the relationship between critical information literacy practices and civic engagement.

Open Reader Series

mediastudies.press

414 W. Broad St. | Bethlehem, PA 18018

www.mediastudies.press